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Problem: Clubs at Harvard Business School set retail prices for their parties and events without visibility into the elasticity of demand. Club parties set the tone of the social scene early in the semester and many students are willing to pay a premium to ensure attendance at “the right” parties. Students rely on informal WhatsApp resales that are opaque, slow, and shaped by social pressure. Or, for a worse experience, Slack. Sellers face and rightfully fear reputational harm if they demand high prices in a small community, so they price opaquely. Buyers who value an event most cannot reliably find supply, especially in the final hours before the event. The result is missed matches, money left on the table for sellers, weak signals for clubs, and frequent last minute scrambles for buyers.
Our solution is an anonymous marketplace for verified HBS community members that runs hourly modified Dutch auctions. Sellers submit redacted QR tickets with price floors. Buyers place bids with cards on file. A pooled ticket escrow enables fast, anonymous clearing and delivery. Clubs gain privacy safe demand curves to inform next year’s retail pricing while fraud checks and email domain identity verification protect the community.

User Personas

Persona 1: Buyer (Co-Primary User)

Name: Maya Chen
Background: First year MBA, Section C. Former product analyst with a tight student budget. Active in the Social Enterprise Club. Desires to attend 3 to 5 social events per week in September.
Motivation and goals: Wants to lock in tickets for high energy events without camping on WhatsApp. Values transparency on whether a bid is realistic and how prices move over time. Wants a clean experience that charges her card only when she clears.
Values and ethics: Fairness, anonymity, and low friction. She dislikes public bargaining in small circles and does not want to overpay a classmate.
Behaviors and tools: Mobile first, uses calendar reminders, and is comfortable saving a card on file.
Pain points: Last minute scrambles, hidden supply, and fear of scams from screenshots of tickets.
Definition of success: Can place a bid, see implied market price and volume, get matched within hours, and receive a valid QR code with clear instructions for transfer.

Persona 2: Seller (Co-Primary User)

Name: Alex Rodriguez
Background: Second year MBA, former consultant. Active in Venture Capital and Soccer Club. Schedule changes often and he sells tickets when travel pops up.
Motivation and goals: Wants to recover costs and make a fair profit without reputational risk. Prefers to set a simple floor and let the market work.

Values and ethics: Community trust and privacy. He wants assurance that buyers are real and that he is not seen as gouging.
Behaviors and tools: Uses desktop to list and mobile to confirm sales. Comfortable uploading a redacted QR.
Pain points: Manual haggling, buyers backing out, and uncertainty about true demand.
Definition of success: Can list in under two minutes, set a price floor, track likely clearing price, and get paid automatically when a trade executes.

Persona 3: Club Executive (Ideal Customer)

Name: Fiona Weatherspoon
Background: Second year MBA, President of the Canada Club in charge of the annual Rodeo party.
Motivation and goals: Wants to use data to inform future parties on pricing and ticket scarcity to raise the maximum funds for club activities.
Values and ethics: Future profit maximization by understanding ticket behavior. May not be focused on end user fairness.
Behaviors and tools: Would use data to open more tickets if necessary, adapt
Pain points: Opaque customer demand makes it difficult to plan an event without relying on institutional knowledge. Experimentation is difficult.
Definition of success: Able to capitalize on early bird and last minute tickets without letting surplus value flow only to resellers.

User Journey

518 words

1. **Discover**
Clubs publish retail tickets as usual. In parallel, the marketplace shows an events feed limited to the HBS community. Maya opens the app and filters by date, club, and expected vibe. Each card displays the current implied price, historical price curve, and a simple liquidity meter that estimates how many tickets are in the pool without revealing exact volume.

2. **Decide**
Maya taps into the event. She sees three helpful elements: a price chart, the recent clear rate per hour, and a bid helper that suggests a likely clearing band based on the last 24 hours. She enters a bid, selects quantity, and saves her card. A preauthorization confirms funds are available, but no charge is made until she clears. She opts into alerts for price moves or successful matches.

3. **List**
Alex's plans change. He chooses the same event, uploads a redacted QR with an in product masking tool, and sets a minimum acceptable price. He can list one transferable unit even if his ticket is named. The ticket enters an escrow pool. Alex is shown a revenue estimate that updates hourly based on market conditions.

4. **Auction cycle**
Hourly, the system runs a modified Dutch auction. Bids are sorted from high to low and asks are sorted from low to high. The engine matches buyers and sellers at the highest market clearing price that respects each seller's floor. Because sellers choose floors, some tickets may not sell in a given round. The algorithm optimizes total seller surplus measured as selling price minus ask to encourage reasonable floors and more listings.

5. **Execution**
When Maya's bid clears, her card is charged and she receives a confirmed QR from the pooled tickets. She also gets a time stamped receipt and usage guidance. Alex is paid the clearing price to his linked payout method. If his floor was not met, his listing rolls to the next round and he can adjust the floor with a slider.

6. **Safety and trust cues**
Both sides see strong identity signals. Accounts require HBS email verification and phone verification. The platform displays community guardrails, such as a visible ceiling on per person daily sales to discourage scalping behaviors. A fraud check runs on uploaded QR codes to detect duplicates and format issues. Buyers acknowledge that events can check IDs and that social norms apply.

7. **Transfer and fulfillment**
The platform sends Maya a verified QR with a unique fingerprint so the event team can flag re-use. She adds it to her Apple Wallet, Google Wallet, or EventBrite. Alex's original QR is locked in the system once sold. If the event supports name changes, the platform submits a change request on clearing. If not, the social trust model is made explicit, and clubs are encouraged to scan with tamper detection.

8. **Aftercare**
Maya rates the fulfillment experience and reports issues. Alex sees his net proceeds and tax summary. The club receives aggregated, privacy safe analytics: demand curve by time, final sell through, and the delta between retail and resale. This data supports better retail pricing and helps set listing caps if needed.

Success Criteria

500 words

Primary outcomes (P0 priority)

Liquidity and speed: Median time to match under 4 hours for bids and asks placed within 7 days of the event. For the 24 hours leading up to the event, median time to match under 60 minutes. During the event, matches can be made in adjustable time as funded by sellers or bidders based on supply/demand curves.

Sell through: At least 70 percent of listed tickets sell before the event starts for events with 15 or more listings.

Price efficiency: Median bid ask spread under 12 percent during the final 48 hours for events with 20 or more active bids.

Trust and safety: Duplicate use rate under 0.10 percent of fulfilled tickets. Confirmed fraud or chargeback rate under 0.30 percent of transactions. Zero critical data incidents.

GMV and revenue: Pilot GMV of 50,000 dollars with positive net marketplace revenue after payment fees.

Secondary outcomes (P1 priority)
6) User adoption: 60 percent of first year students create an account and 35 percent place at least one bid or listing during the pilot.
7) Club retention and insight use: 80 percent of participating clubs run resale again and 70 percent use the demand data to adjust retail price bands in subsequent cycles.
8) Fulfillment quality: 95 percent of fulfilled buyers scan successfully at the door on first attempt, confirmed by club feedback.
9) Customer effort: Median time to list a ticket under 2 minutes and median time to place a bid under 60 seconds.

Qualitative measures (P2 priority)
10) Perceived fairness: In a short anonymous pulse survey of buyers and sellers each month, fewer than 15 percent agree that the marketplace encourages gouging.
11) Transparency: Majority of respondents report the implied pricing chart and liquidity meter helped them set a realistic bid or floor.

Externalities to monitor
A) Scalping pressure: Track high volume sellers and cap per person daily listings to reduce speculative buying.
B) Club revenue impacts: Compare retail sell out speed and observed resale premiums to inform whether clubs should release more tiers or adjust supply.
C) Community norms: Track reports of inappropriate behavior in chat or attempts to re use QR codes and escalate to club admins when necessary. Verified email addresses tied to identities make this easy.

Security, privacy, and compliance requirements:
- All accounts verified with HBS email and phone.
- Card data tokenized via a PCI compliant payment processor. No card data is stored on our servers.
- QR uploads stored with encryption at rest and access controls.
- Event data shared with clubs only in aggregated, privacy preserving form.

- Clear reporting flow for suspected fraud, with rapid nullification of compromised QR codes when events support reissue.

Relative priority rationale

Liquidity, safety, and GMV are Priority 0 because they determine whether the market clears and whether participants can trust the system. Adoption, retention, and fulfillment quality are P1 since they improve scale after core performance is proven. Perception metrics are P2 and validate ethics and transparency as the product matures.